



▲ A PAGODA AT THE HUMBLE ADMINISTRATOR'S GARDEN

Temple of Agriculture

Location Beijing, China

In a country periodically racked by famines, the importance of China's harvests loomed large. Dedicated to Xiannong, the father of agriculture, the Temple of Agriculture was built in 1420 to celebrate abundant harvests. It sits in a 1.2-square-mile (3-square-km) complex, complete with its own palace, the Qing Cheng

Palace. It was to the temple's Jufu Hall that the emperor himself came every year at the spring equinox for the Tilling Ritual. The temple is a single-story building, much of it of a deep-red lacquer, with complex geometrical patterning highlighted in gold. Above the lower level is a blue-and-green frieze, filled with sumptuous details, and a sweeping, dragon-studded roof of green glazed tiles. Having fallen into almost complete dilapidation, the entire complex was painstakingly restored from 2001.

Humble Administrator's Garden

Location Suzhou, China

The central principle behind Chinese gardening has been to co-opt nature, so as to create an idealized, harmonious vision of the world. Suzhou, in southern China, was particularly famed for its gardens, and the Humble

Administrator's Garden, laid out by a former court official in the early 16th century, is the largest and most celebrated of all. It comprises three sections—Eastern, Western, and Central—arranged around a large lake, making water the dominant element of the garden. Ponds and streams, rocks and bridges, as well as many pavilions and monuments, are artfully combined to create an apparent informality. The mood of the setting is contemplative, serene, and refined.